

Keeping Our Eyes on the Prize!

Moving Employment Forward Post-Covid-19

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SELN working documents contain information collected in response to SELN state member requests. An SELN working document is intended to share work in progress and may not be a comprehensive analysis or compilation.

The SELN envisions a world where employment for people with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD) includes:

- working at an individual job in a local business
- earning the prevailing wage for that position or industry
- working alongside people who do not have disabilities
- working at businesses located within our communities that are not owned or managed by the support organization (or provider)¹

This vision is grounded in the knowledge that, with appropriate supports, all working-age adults can become economically self-sufficient members of the workforce. The service system must reflect the reality that employment occurs within an individual's life experiences, including family, daytime, home, and community supports².

This document is the first in a SELN series summarizing the ongoing learning occurring in SELN member states as they focus on individual competitive integrated employment during and after the COVID-19 pandemic³.

Introduction

Since March 2020, state IDD agencies have been working through the Public Health Emergency (PHE) to ensure individuals with IDD continue to have access to high-quality, integrated employment services. During the COVID-19 pandemic, we have learned how to more efficiently use technology to assist individuals in achieving their employment goals.

How did we get here?

Prior to the COVID-19 pandemic, states were dedicated to developing and implementing integrated employment and community life engagement services that maximized the active participation of individuals with IDD in their community. States have taken many actions over the years to facilitate this work:

- States are focused on reaching compliance with the Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services Home and Community Based Services (HCBS) rules by March 2023⁴. This compliance process includes assessing the settings where services are provided, modifying state Medicaid and IDD agency policy and practice, and collaborating with other state agencies, such as vocational rehabilitation and education.
- States have worked to ensure individuals have opportunities to make self-determined and experientially informed choices about working in the community. States have been developing new services, such as discovery and career exploration. States have also been modifying legacy pre-vocational services to focus on supporting individuals to set goals that lead to a competitive integrated job.
- States have worked to ensure that families and other community stakeholders have accurate knowledge about the impact of integrated employment on the lives of individuals with IDD. They have done this by developing outreach materials on the benefits of employment, creating venues for families and individuals to share employment stories, and expanding financial literacy and benefits management services.
- States have worked to ensure that providers have the knowledge and skills necessary to transition their service models from facility-based to community-based services. They have done this by implementing tiered standards as a strategy to come into compliance with the HCBS rules. They have also closed admissions to certain disability-specific facility-based service options and are supporting providers to examine and transform business practices.
- States have worked to ensure that employment professionals have access to the skills necessary to provide high-quality employment services efficiently and effectively. They have done this by strengthening employment staff qualifications including training and certification requirements, and by offering resources to assist providers to ensure their workforce meets the standards.

Where are we going?

The COVID-19 pandemic has impacted states' efforts to increase the number of people working and engaging in their communities. Some impacts, such as the interruption of face-to-face services, have slowed down the process of planning for and obtaining a job in the community. Other impacts, such as the use of technology as a method to deliver services, have led to the wider use of innovative person-centered practices.

This working document will focus on technology's impact on individual employment opportunities and outcomes. Future working documents will focus on:

- Opportunities for individuals to increase independence
- Opportunities for increased flexibility at the individual and provider levels
- Opportunities for individuals to increase their social network and build and sustain personal relationships
- Purchase and usage costs of technology at the individual and provider levels

How has technology had an impact?

Several barriers have historically impeded the use of technology as a method to deliver employment and day services, including:

- state policy and financing
- direct support staff expertise
- acceptance by employers and human resource staff
- widespread digital literacy issues

*(Administration for Community Living, 2015⁵;
National Council on Disability, 2018⁶).*

Since March 2020, due to the COVID-19 pandemic, the use of technology has expanded dramatically as an important tool for delivering employment and day services to individuals with IDD. Staff began delivering services by telephone, smartphone, tablet,

and computer. As the pandemic continued these virtual approaches have become necessary and more accepted. Individuals with IDD have demonstrated significant capacity to interact and learn through these modes (Kennedy-Lizotte & Butterworth, 2021⁷).

Examples of how technology has enhanced states' efforts related to integrated employment and community engagement during the COVID-19 pandemic include:

- **Using technology to provide job supports.** Providing job coaching through videoconferencing and app-based prompts and resources has enhanced opportunities for independence, individualization, and inclusion. While research prior to the pandemic has shown that technology is effective in reducing reliance on job coaching and increasing personal independence (Collins & Collet-Klingenberg, 2018⁸; Cullen et al., 2017⁹), many states, individuals with IDD, providers, and employment staff were hesitant to use it.
- **Using in-person and video events for job exploration.** Providers have used live and recorded video to improve access to job shadowing activities that support individuals to expand their knowledge about the types of jobs available in their community.
- **Offering employment services that emphasize flexibility and choice.** For many individuals, the pandemic resulted in the temporary closure of facility-based programs. Consequently, it also provided the opportunity to increase flexibility in scheduling through a combination of in-person and virtual service options which many individuals, families and staff expect to continue after the pandemic.
- **Reimagining staffing patterns.** With adjustments in state policy and practice guidelines, staff can support individual outcomes and learning without focusing as rigidly on working during specific times of the day. Remote options and an enhanced emphasis on natural workplace support also create flexibility in staff time allocation.
- **Focusing job development and supports on the individual and their support networks.** Best practice encourages direct support professionals to ask individuals with IDD to identify important members of their social network who can help to support employment goals. Research conducted prior to 2020 (Migliore et al., 2018¹⁰) found that this

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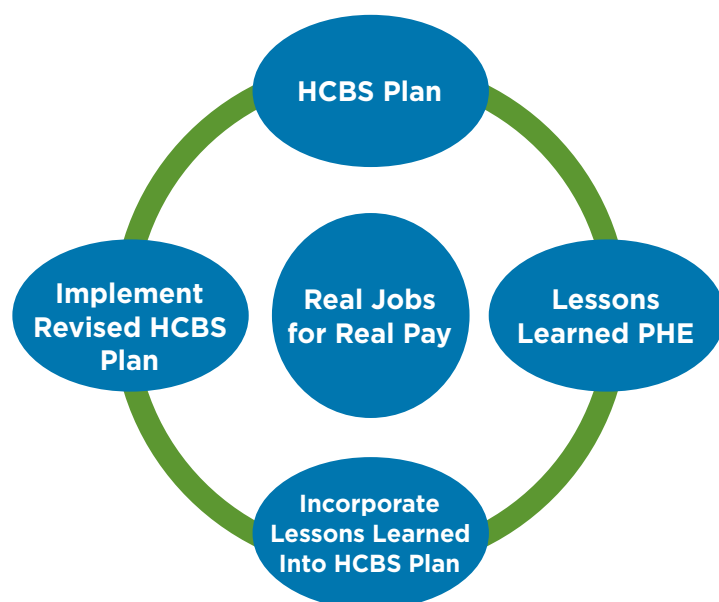
practice did not regularly occur. The increased use of technology has made it easier for direct support professionals to engage with individuals' networks in more typical settings and reach more members of the job seeker's network.

During the COVID-19 pandemic, states were able to pay for the use of technology in the delivery of employment and day services by including it as a reimbursable model in their HCBS 1915C Medicaid waiver Appendix K. States will have six months after the close of the Public Health Emergency before their Appendix K approvals expire. Retaining the ability to deliver employment and day services in-person and through technology may require state Medicaid agencies to revise current approved waivers. It may also require state Medicaid agencies to develop new waiver types and applications. States must be proactive and plan for the expiration of Appendix K to avoid a negative impact on communities, individuals, families, services providers, and staff.

Key action steps

This SELN working document series will describe four key action steps to consider as state IDD agencies work with their stakeholders to use all available strategies to improve integrated employment and community integration. We developed these key action steps based on dialogue with SELN member states from September 2020-February 2021 through network-wide discussions and state-level technical assistance. These key action steps will:

- support states to increase the number of people working in real jobs, for real pay
- further efforts toward compliance with the Medicaid HCBS rules
- identify lessons learned from the pandemic
- incorporate new knowledge into states' current and revised plans to reach compliance with the Medicaid HCBS rules
- influence state system employment and day services' policies and procedures.



KEY ACTION STEPS

1. Identify opportunities in your system to increase worker independence by strengthening the use of natural supports and technology.
2. Identify opportunities in your system to increase individualization and flexibility in scheduling, service activities, service settings, and support types.
3. Identify opportunities in your system to facilitate individuals to increase their social network and to build and sustain new and existing personal relationships.
4. Determine if you need to take additional actions to address the cost of technology purchase and usage at the individual level and provider level, training and technical assistance on the use of technology at the individual level and provider level, and how you can maintain individual privacy during the receipt of telehealth services.

SELN staff will continue to refine the action steps based upon ongoing conversations with member states, federal partners, and other stakeholders. We are drafting additional working documents related to key action steps 1-4.

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Endnotes

- 1 www.selnhub.org/home
- 2 State Employment Leadership Network. (2015). State Employment Leadership Network Funding Statement: An Essential Strategy to Support Integrated Employment. The State Employment Leadership Networks is a project of the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston and the National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities Services. www.selnhub.org/resources/item/58/67
- 3 Under the Home and Community Based Waiver Services taxonomy the term telehealth is used by the Center for Medicare and Medicaid Services. Terms used by state IDD agencies to date have included telehealth, remote and virtual options. As of June 2021 the use of these terms by stakeholders is fluid across stakeholders.
- 4 Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services. (2014). Medicaid program; state plan home and community-based services, 5-year period for waivers, provider payment reassignment, and home and community-based setting requirements for community first choice (Section 1915(k) of the Act) and home and community-based services (HCBS) waivers (Section 1915(c) of the Act). Retrieved from <https://www.federalregister.gov/documents/2014/01/16/2014-00487/medicaid-program-state-plan-home-and-community-based-services-5-year-period-for-waivers-provider>
- 5 Administration for Community Living. (2015). Report to the President—Leveling the playing field: Improving technology access and design for people with intellectual disabilities. Washington, D.C.: The President’s Committee for People with Intellectual Disabilities. <https://acl.gov/sites/default/files/programs/2017-03/PCPID-2015-Report-to-President.pdf>
- 6 National Council on Disability. (2018). National disability employment policy, from the new deal to the real deal: Joining the industries of the future. Washington, DC: National Council on Disability.
- 7 Lizotte-Kennedy, R. & Butterworth, J. (2021). Weathering the Pandemic: Employment and Day Service Delivery. IMPACT, University of Minnesota Institute for Community Integration. <https://publications.ici.umn.edu/impact/34-1/weathering-the-pandemic>
- 8 Collins, J.C. & Collet-Klingenberg, L. (2018). Portable electronic assistive technology to improve vocational task completion in young adults with an intellectual disability: A review of the literature. *Journal of Intellectual Disabilities* 22(3) 213–232.
- 9 Cullen, J. M., Alber-Morgan, S. R., Simmons-Reed, E.A., & Izzo, M. V. (2017). Effects of self-directed video prompting using iPads on the vocational task completion of young adults with intellectual and developmental disabilities. *Journal of Vocational Rehabilitation*, 46, 361–375.
- 10 Migliore, A., Nye-Lengerman, K., Lyons, O., Bose, J., & Butterworth, J. (2018). A comprehensive model of employment supports for job seekers with intellectual and developmental disabilities. *Journal of Rehabilitation*, 84(2), 3–13.



State Employment Leadership Network

The State Employment Leadership Network (SELN) is a cross-state cooperative venture of state MR/DD agencies that are committed to improving employment outcomes for adolescents and adults with developmental disabilities. Working documents contain information collected in response to state requests, and federal, state and local initiatives of interest to the SELN membership. They are intended to share work in progress but may not be a comprehensive analysis or compilation. Working documents are updated over time as information changes.

The SELN is a joint program of the Institute for Community Inclusion at UMass Boston and the National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities Services.



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